would satisfy everyone diminished. Nevertheless, no signs or developments have been identified that really threaten the continuation of his rule.

The United States: The Attempt to Decipher the True Signal

From the end of the Second World War in 1945 until the collapse of the Soviet Union, the Cold War was the main instrument that shaped and stabilized the global order. Since the Soviet Union's collapse in 1991, it had been a virtual cold war, in which the United States served as the only "policeman" of a unipolar world for a decade, until 2000.

The election of President Barack Obama in 2008 marked a major strategic change in US foreign policy. Obama changed the strategy from one of confrontation to one of engagement. Presumably, President Obama truly believed that the engagement strategy would be successful. But when the global reality appeared more and more to be a battleground between a Muslim culture that was not interested in compromise and a culture of liberal democracy, whose leader was emerging from an economic crisis at home and who was embroiled in two wars with no end in sight, and whose main ally, Europe, was grappling unsuccessfully with Islam on its own soil, there was no doubt that the strategy of engagement was going to be interpreted by the Muslim world as weakness, with the understanding that all it needed to do was to continue to erode the power and influence of the United States.

Below I will present an assortment of opinions that were heard in Washington in 2015, from government officials, members of Congress, and people in security, intelligence, and academia.

The US administration was preoccupied with the deterioration in Afghanistan and Pakistan and the situation in Iraq, so it treated Iran as a lower priority, even though that country was geographically located between Afghanistan and Iraq and was in the process of obtaining a nuclear bomb. This order of priorities derived from the administration's considerations regarding the future of NATO, the threat of another terrorist attack of a 9/11 magnitude, the danger of a nuclear war in Southern Asia, and the president's low approval ratings (one must keep in mind that wars have a tendency to bedevil an American president's term).